



**Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd**

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# **LEARNER GUIDE**

For

## **Achieving Sales Goals with Customer-Centric Selling Techniques**

Course Code: C1088

Conducted by

**Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd**

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**Version 4.0**

## DOCUMENT VERSION CONTROL RECORD

| Version Number | Effective Date of Release | Summary of Included Changes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Author                            |
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| 1.0            | 06 Mar 2025               | First version.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Tertiary Infotech Pte Ltd         |
| 2.0            | 17 Oct 2025               | Update company name.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd |
| 3.0            | 17 Aug 2026               | Regenerated to match the redesigned v7 slide deck. Added a detailed round-by-round facilitation guide to each of the 4 role-play activities (one per Learning Unit) — the ordered rounds, a suggested timing breakdown, the target artefact and a self-check list. The slide deck deliberately carries no step-by-step instructions, so this guide is the learner's working document during each role play. Each activity is also published as a standalone artefact pack under activities/NN - <Activity>/. | Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd |
| 4.0            | 02 Oct 2026               | Non-WSQ edition for C1088 Achieving Sales Goals with Customer-Centric Selling Techniques, replicated from the v8 courseware: same four Learning Units, topics and role-play activities; assessment and programme-specific administration removed; each day retimed to 9:30am–5:30pm (7.5 instructional hours).                                                                                                                                                                                               | Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd |

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## How to Use This Guide

This Learner Guide accompanies the course Achieving Sales Goals with Customer-Centric Selling Techniques (C1088), conducted by Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd. It covers 4 Learning Units and 4 in-class role-play activities.

Use this guide alongside the course slides during class, and as your reference after the course. Each Learning Unit section below lists the key concepts, followed by the one role-play activity you will complete in class for that unit. For each activity you get the full scenario, the roles to assign, a detailed round-by-round guide to running it, a suggested timing breakdown, the artefact you will produce, a self-check list, the discussion and decision prompts, and a debrief check.

The slides deliberately do not carry the step-by-step round instructions — your trainer facilitates the scenario, roles and discussion from the deck while you work through the detailed rounds here (and in the matching activities/NN - <Activity>/ANN-Facilitator-Guide-\*.pdf artefact pack). This is a role-play-based soft-skills course, so activities are illustrated with scripted scenario dialogue and observer scorecards rather than software screenshots.

Before you start, you will need:

- A notebook or the worksheet in this guide to capture your Observer/Coach notes.
- A willingness to play a role in character — salesperson, buyer, or Observer/Coach.
- The course slides (downloaded from the LMS) for reference during activities and after the course.

## Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Develop recommendation guidelines based on customer preferences and needs.
- LO2: Develop upselling and cross-selling techniques to enhance sales closure.
- LO3: Develop sales follow-up processes to improve customer engagement.
- LO4: Develop evaluation metrics for the sales closure process to measure performance.

## LU1 — Foundations of Selling

Mindset · Empathy · Sales Strategy · Buyer Psychology · Discovery

### Key concepts

- Selling is a human, empathy-driven conversation — mindset shapes the outcome before any technique does.
- Empathy is a trainable skill, not a personality trait: see their world, suspend judgement, and name the emotion out loud (affect labelling).

- A sales strategy starts with the math of sales — leads to conversations to proposals to closes — and a written goal for every call.
- Buyer psychology (Cialdini's principles, the buyer's matrix, the illusion of choice) shapes how a prospect actually decides.
- Discovery uses Bucket, Why-Why-Why, SPIN and Gap questions, always with permission, to uncover the real need before recommending anything.

## Selling Mindset

You will be able to: adopt a confident, human, fear-reduced mindset before any sales conversation.

### What it is

- **Sell Like a Human** — Talk to a person solving a problem, not a quota to close.
- **Want It Genuinely** — Real desire to help the buyer win is what sustains persistence.
- **Confidence From Prep** — Confidence comes from preparation, not from volume or bravado.
- **Reduce the Fear** — A 'no' is information about fit — never a verdict on your worth.

### How Mindset Shapes the Call

- **Prepare With Intent** — Know the buyer's likely world, not just your pitch.
- **Lead With Curiosity** — Open with a real question, never a script.
- **Regulate Yourself** — Pause, name your own reaction, then respond.
- **Stay Outcome-Focused** — Keep attention on their goal, not your commission.

*Self-regulation is the skill: the pause between what you feel and what you say is where the deal is protected.*

## Fear-Driven vs Confidence-Driven Selling

### FEAR-DRIVEN

- **Rushes to Pitch** — Fills every silence with more features.
- **Takes It Personally** — Hears an objection as a personal judgement.
- **Over-Promises** — Says yes to anything rather than lose the deal.

### CONFIDENCE-DRIVEN

- **Asks, Then Waits** — Asks a real question and can sit with the pause.
- **Hears a Request** — Treats an objection as a request for information.
- **States Limits Honestly** — Trust outlasts any single transaction.

### Why Mindset Comes First

- **70% — Buy on feeling:** of customers buy based on how they feel about the seller
- **+50% — High-EQ advantage:** reported outperformance of high-EQ sellers vs peers

- **93% — Non-verbal:** commonly-cited share of meaning carried beyond the words

*Directional figures, widely cited in sales-EI literature — use them to make the point, not as precise benchmarks.*

*Source: emotional-intelligence-in-sales literature (Cerdeña Dubó, LinkedIn, 2025; Paperflite) — commonly-cited industry figures*

## Empathy as a Sales Skill

You will be able to: apply empathy and affect labelling as a deliberate, trainable selling technique.

### What it is

- **See Their World** — Take the buyer's perspective as they actually experience it.
- **Stay Non-Judgemental** — Drop the verdict on whether their concern is reasonable.
- **Separate Your Feelings** — Recognise your own reaction as yours, not theirs.
- **Prioritise Their Story** — Their account of the problem outranks your pitch.

### Affect Labelling — Noll's 'Listen to the Emotions'

- **Listen Beneath the Words** — Track the feeling driving the sentence, not its content.
- **Name the Emotion** — Reflect it back plainly: "You're frustrated by the delays."
- **Let It Land** — Say nothing. Recognition needs a moment to register.
- **Resume Rationally** — Once the reaction settles, the problem-solving can start.

*Affect labelling dampens the brain's reactive centres — Doug Noll reports it can restore rational dialogue in under 90 seconds.*

### Sympathy vs Empathy — Only One of Them Sells

#### Sympathy

- "I'm sorry you're dealing with that."
- Feels AT the buyer, from a distance.
- Closes the topic and moves on to the pitch.
- Leaves the buyer still holding the problem alone.

#### Empathy

- "So the deadline slipped and you took the heat."
- Feels WITH the buyer, from beside them.
- Opens the topic so the real need can surface.
- Makes the buyer feel accurately understood.

### Empathy Map — John, the Buyer You'll Meet in the Role Play

- **Says** — "We're missing deadlines we used to hit."; "I've sat through a lot of these demos."
- **Thinks** — "Will this be another tool nobody adopts?"; "Is this rep actually listening to me?"
- **Does** — Tracks every job on shared spreadsheets.; Chases his team manually for status updates.
- **Feels** — Exposed when a deadline slips publicly.; Wary of being sold to after past regrets.

*Source: empathy-mapping practice, grounded in this course's role-play persona*

## Real-world example

**Xerox — The First Formal 'Ask Before You Pitch' Sales Method.** Xerox's Professional Selling Skills (PSS) programme, developed in the 1960s-70s, was among the first to formalise buyer-centred questioning over a hard pitch — the direct ancestor of the discovery-led, empathy-aware selling taught in this course.

## Sales Strategy

You will be able to: build a sales strategy from the math of sales and clear goal setting.

### What it is

- **The Math of Sales** — Every sale is a chain of ratios — know yours by heart.
- **Written Call Goals** — One specific, stated aim per call beats 'try to sell'.
- **Find the Bottleneck** — Fix the weakest ratio, not the loudest complaint.
- **Protect the Pipeline** — Today's prospecting is next quarter's commission.

### The Math of Sales — Where Deals Actually Leak

- **Leads** — 100 — Prospects entering the pipeline this week.
- **Conversations** — 20 — Leads who agree to a genuine conversation.
- **Proposals** — 9 — Conversations reaching a real recommendation.
- **Closes** — 3 — Proposals that convert into a signed sale.

*A weak leads-to-conversations ratio is a prospecting problem. A weak proposals-to-closes ratio is a closing problem. Different fix entirely.*

### Vague Activity vs Goal-Driven Activity

#### Vague Activity

- "I'll make some calls today."
- No idea which ratio in the chain is actually weak.
- Success is whatever happens to land.
- Busy all week, no idea if it worked.

#### Goal-Driven Activity

- "I will book 5 discovery calls from 20 dials today."
- Tracks each stage to find the real bottleneck.
- Success is a stated, specific, checkable target.
- Knows by Friday exactly what to change on Monday.

### What the Industry Data Says About Closing

- **29% — Average close rate:** reported across industries — the bar is lower than you fear
- **48% — Calls with no close:** of sales calls end without the seller ever asking
- **5-12 — Contacts needed:** 80% of sales close only after this many touches

*Nearly half of all calls end without anyone asking for the business. Simply asking, properly, is a measurable edge.*

*Source: sales-benchmark synthesis (alexberman.com; Lusha via monday.com) — industry-reported figures*

### Understanding Buyer Psychology

You will be able to: apply Cialdini's principles of influence and the buyer's matrix to how prospects decide.

#### What it is

- **Why People Really Buy** — To solve a felt problem — logic arrives afterwards to justify it.
- **The Power of Words** — Concrete language outsells vague claims every time.
- **The Illusion of Choice** — Two good options feel empowering; one feels like pressure.
- **Trust Beats Charm** — Consistency and follow-through, not personality, build trust.

#### How Trust Is Actually Built During a Call

- **Consistency** — Say the same thing you will later do.
- **Tone** — Match your energy to the buyer's, not your mood.
- **Follow-Through** — Do the small promised thing, exactly on time.
- **Reciprocation** — Give real insight before asking for anything.

### The Buyer's Matrix — Map Every Stakeholder Before You Pitch

**Gatekeeper:** High power, low interest; Keep them briefly, credibly informed; Never surprise them late in the deal

**Champion:** High power, high interest; Co-design the proposal with them; Arm them to sell it internally

**Bystander:** Low power, low interest; Light touch — don't over-invest; Monitor in case their role changes

**Advocate:** Low power, high interest; Give them talking points for others; Their enthusiasm travels upward

### Cialdini's Principles at Work in a Sales Call

- **Reciprocity** — Give real value before you ask for anything.
- **Commitment** — Small agreed steps make the big yes feel safe.
- **Social Proof** — Show what similar buyers chose, and why.
- **Authority** — Demonstrate expertise; never merely claim it.
- **Liking** — Genuine rapport makes agreement easier.
- **Scarcity** — State real limits only — never fabricate one.
- **Unity** — A shared identity or goal beats surface liking.

*Source: Cialdini, R. — Influence (1984); Pre-Suasion (2016, adds Unity)*

### Discovery Process

You will be able to: run a permission-based discovery conversation using SPIN-style questioning.

#### What it is

- **The Point of Discovery** — Uncover the real need before recommending anything.
- **Bucket Questions** — Broad openers that let the buyer pick what matters.
- **Why, Why, Why** — Repeated whys dig from symptom to the felt problem.
- **Permission-Based Selling** — Ask before you probe — consent keeps them in control.

### SPIN Selling — Rackham's Question Sequence

- **Situation** — What does the current process actually look like?
- **Problem** — Where specifically is it breaking down?
- **Implication** — What is that difficulty really costing?
- **Need-Payoff** — What would solving it be worth to you?

### Closed Questions vs Gap Questions

#### Closed Questions

- "Are you happy with your current system?"
- Invites a one-word answer that ends the conversation.
- Reveals almost nothing about the real gap.
- You leave the call still guessing.

#### Gap Questions

- "What would it mean if you solved this for good?"
- Invites the buyer to describe the gap in their own words.

- Surfaces the implication they hadn't said out loud.
- They talk themselves toward the decision.

### Bucket Questions — Let the Buyer Choose the Topic

- **People** — "How is your team handling the workload now?"
- **Process** — "Walk me through how a job gets tracked today."
- **Technology** — "What tools are you relying on, and where do they fall short?"
- **Priorities** — "What would make the biggest difference this quarter?"

Source: Bucket-question discovery technique

### Activity 1 — Role Play: Foundations of Selling (Role Play)

Objective: apply mindset, empathy, buyer psychology and discovery questioning in a live sales call.

#### Scenario

Jessica is a sales rep for CloudFlow, a cloud-based project-management platform. John is a project manager at Sunrise Builders, a mid-sized construction firm in Singapore, where every job is tracked on shared spreadsheets. Since the team grew from 8 to 19, two handover deadlines have slipped because updates never reached the right person — and John's director asked him about it in front of the team.

This is Jessica's first real conversation with John. Her goal for the call is NOT to sell software: it is to earn enough trust to run a genuine discovery conversation. John has sat through several demos before, bought a tool two years ago that nobody adopted, and is quietly testing whether this rep is any different.

The scene runs from the opening minute — mindset, rapport, permission to ask — through discovery using Why-Why-Why and Gap questions, into a solution shaped by what John actually said, addressing his fear of another failed rollout, and closing on one concrete next step.

#### You'll produce

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard citing specific lines for mindset, a Gap Question, affect labelling, a principle of influence, and a buying signal (Duration: 1 hour.)

#### Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **Jessica — Sales Rep, CloudFlow** — *Goal: Earn trust and uncover John's real project-tracking pain before proposing anything.* Trained to lead with permission-based discovery, not a features list. She must resist pitching for the first five minutes, however tempting John's opening complaint makes it.

- **John — Project Manager, Sunrise Builders — Goal:** *Decide whether this rep genuinely understands construction chaos, or is just selling.* Burned by a tool his team never adopted. He will open with a surface complaint ('we just need better reminders') that is NOT the real problem — the real problem is that he is personally accountable for information he cannot see.
- **Observer / Coach — Goal:** *Score the conversation against the Foundations checklist and give usable feedback.* Watches for mindset language, affect labelling, genuine Gap questions, named principles of influence, and the moment hesitation turns into a buying signal. Quotes exact lines in the debrief — never general impressions.

### How to run it — round by round

These are the detailed rounds for this role play. Work through them in order; your trainer will facilitate from the slides while you work from this guide (the matching activities/NN - <Activity>/ANN-Facilitator-Guide-\*.pdf carries the same sequence as a standalone sheet).

1. **Assign the three roles** — One learner plays Jessica (sales rep, CloudFlow project-management SaaS), one plays John (buyer, project manager at Sunrise Builders, a mid-sized construction firm). Everyone else is Observer/Coach for this round, working from the scorecard in the worksheet.
2. **Round 1 — open honestly, not with a script** — Jessica opens by stating her real intent before asking anything — something like 'before we get into details, I want to make sure I understand your needs so we focus on what actually helps you.' John responds with his real, specific frustration (missed deadlines, spreadsheets not scaling). The Observer notes whether Jessica's opener sounded human or scripted.
3. **Round 2 — climb the discovery ladder** — Jessica asks a genuine Gap Question ('what specifically isn't working with the current system?'), then follows John's answer with at least one Why-Why-Why chain to get from a surface complaint ('spreadsheets aren't cutting it') down to the real cause ('the team outgrew that method as we scaled'). John should only reveal the deeper cause once actually asked — don't let Jessica skip straight to pitching.
4. **Round 3 — present a solution tied to what John just said** — Jessica presents CloudFlow using the Power of Words (specific, concrete benefits framed around John's stated pain, e.g. 'you'll never chase a status update again') and offers the Illusion of Choice: a small pilot with one team versus a full rollout — never a single take-it-or-leave-it option.
5. **Round 4 — handle the hesitation and reduce fear** — John raises a genuine concern about the transition (time, disruption to a busy team). Jessica reduces that fear with something concrete — a trial period, free onboarding support, a guarantee — not just verbal reassurance ('trust me, it'll be fine').
6. **Close on a specific, dated next step** — Jessica confirms a concrete onboarding date rather than a vague 'let's stay in touch.' John should be able to say the date back in his own words before the round ends.

7. **Observer completes the scorecard** — Using the worksheet, the Observer writes down the exact line used for the mindset opener, the Gap Question, the principle of influence in play (name it: reciprocity, social proof, authority, liking, scarcity, unity, or commitment/consistency), and the buying signal that triggered the close.

### Suggested timing

| Minutes | Phase                                                                     |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 min   | Brief the scenario and assign the three roles                             |
| 10 min  | Round 1 — Open with mindset, not a pitch                                  |
| 15 min  | Round 2 — Run the discovery ladder (Gap Questions, Why-Why-Why)           |
| 10 min  | Round 3 — Present the solution using influence and the illusion of choice |
| 10 min  | Round 4 — Build trust, reduce fear, and close on a dated next step        |
| 10 min  | Observer scores the call and runs the debrief                             |

### Your artefact

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard citing the exact line used for the opening mindset, one genuine Gap Question, one named principle of influence, and the buying signal that led to the close.

### Before you debrief — self-check

- Jessica's opening line explicitly set a non-pushy, human mindset before any pitch.
- At least one genuine Gap Question and one Why-Why-Why chain were actually used, not skipped.
- The Observer can name a specific Cialdini principle in play, with the exact line quoted.
- A concrete trust-builder (not just words) was offered before the close attempt.
- The round ended with a specific, dated next step John could repeat back.

### Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Watch for Jessica reverting to a feature dump the instant John hesitates — redirect her back to a question, not a longer pitch.
- The most common miss is jumping from the opener straight to presenting a solution — insist the discovery ladder (Gap Question, then Why-Why-Why) actually happens on screen.
- If a pair finishes early, re-run the close with John raising a harder, more specific objection about budget approval.

### Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

8. Where did Jessica's mindset actually show up in her word choice — and where did it slip into pitching?
9. Which questions were genuine Gap Questions, and which were closed questions dressed up as open ones?
10. Did Jessica ever name John's emotion out loud (affect labelling)? What changed in the conversation right after — or what was missed by skipping it?
11. Which of Cialdini's principles did Jessica use, deliberately or not — and did it land as genuinely helpful or as manipulation?
12. At what exact line did John's hesitation become a buying signal rather than a polite brush-off?
13. John's stated problem was 'better reminders'. What was the real problem underneath, and which question surfaced it?

### Reflect & Discuss

- What surprised you about how quickly trust built once Jessica asked permission to ask questions?
- Did the two-option close (pilot vs full rollout) feel empowering to the buyer, or like pressure in disguise?
- Which single question from the discovery phase would you steal for your own next sales call?

### Debrief it

**Check:** The observer can quote at least one specific mindset moment, one genuine Gap Question, one attempt at naming John's emotion, one named principle of influence, and one real buying signal — with the exact line cited, not a general impression.

## LU2 — Selling Techniques & Problem-Solving

Problem-Based Selling · Demos · Upselling & Cross-Selling · Personalisation · Champions

### Key concepts

- Problem-based selling and 'What Would Your Customer Say?' put the customer's own words — not the salesperson's script — at the centre of the pitch.
- A great demo Educates (the what), Demonstrates (the how) and builds Buy-In (the why) — in that order, never skipped.
- Upselling and cross-selling only land once the customer has realised value from what they already bought, and only when the add-on is genuinely relevant.
- Personalisation means proving you remember what they told you — and adapting to the analytical, relationship, decisive or cautious buyer in front of you.

- Champion Selling equips someone inside the organisation to win the argument you will never be in the room for.

## Problem-Based Selling

You will be able to: lead with the customer's stated problem rather than the product's feature list.

### What it is

- **Start From the Problem** — Open with their difficulty, never with your feature list.
- **Use Their Own Words** — Repeat the phrase they used — not your marketing copy.
- **Quantify the Cost** — A problem with a number attached earns a budget.
- **Confirm Before Solving** — "Have I got that right?" before you propose anything.

### The 'What Would Your Customer Say?' Test

- **Write Your Pitch** — Draft the claim exactly as you'd say it aloud.
- **Read It as the Buyer** — Would they recognise their own situation in it?
- **Strip the Jargon** — Cut any word they would never use themselves.
- **Re-Test With a Real Quote** — Rebuild it around something they actually said.

*If your buyer wouldn't say the sentence out loud, it isn't a benefit — it's marketing copy.*

## Feature-Led vs Problem-Led Conversations

### Feature-Led

- "We offer real-time dashboards and 40+ integrations."
- Buyer must work out what any of it means for them.
- Competes on specification, so price becomes the deciding factor.
- The demo is a lecture the buyer sits through.

### Problem-Led

- "You said updates get lost between site and office — here's that gap closed."
- Buyer immediately sees their own situation solved.
- Competes on outcome, so value justifies the price.
- The demo is a conversation the buyer steers.

## Why Deals Actually Stall

- **61% — Lost to indecision:** of lost deals go to buyer indecision, not a rival
- **80% — Committee stalls:** of B2B committee decisions stall without consensus
- **60% — Say no first:** of prospects say no four times before saying yes

*Your real competitor is usually 'do nothing'. Sell the cost of standing still as hard as you sell the solution.*

Source: B2B sales-benchmark synthesis (alexberman.com) — industry-reported figures

## Running a Great Demo

You will be able to: structure a demonstration around Educate, Demonstrate and Buy-In.

### What it is

- **Educate — The What** — Frame the problem so the solution makes sense.
- **Demonstrate — The How** — Show the specific fix for their specific pain.
- **Buy-In — The Why** — Let them picture their own team using it.
- **Confirm — The Check** — Trial-close each section before moving on.

### The Demo Pyramid — Build In This Order

- **Their Problem** — Restate the difficulty in the buyer's own words.
- **The Mechanism** — Show only the part that fixes that difficulty.
- **The Proof** — Evidence it has worked for someone like them.
- **The Buy-In** — They describe how they would use it themselves.

*Never demo a feature the buyer has not already told you they need.*

### The Feature Tour vs The Earned Demo

#### THE FEATURE TOUR

- Shows Everything — Twenty features, none of them asked for.
- Runs Long — The buyer disengages before the relevant part.
- Ends in Silence — "Any questions?" — and there are none.

#### THE EARNED DEMO

- Shows Three Things — Only what maps to a stated problem.
- Runs Interactive — Trial closes keep the buyer talking throughout.
- Ends in a Next Step — "What would rollout look like for you?"

### Mini Closes — Small Yeses Along the Way

- **The Sense Check** — "Does that approach make sense so far?"
- **The Fit Check** — "Is that closer to how your team works?"
- **The Gap Check** — "Anything missing from what I've shown?"
- **The Forward Check** — "Shall I show you how rollout would work?"

Source: trial-close / mini-close technique (alexberman.com; sales practice)

## Upselling & Cross-Selling

You will be able to: apply upselling and cross-selling with the right timing and genuine relevance.

## What it is

- **Upselling** — A better version of the thing they already chose.
- **Cross-Selling** — A genuinely related add-on that completes the job.
- **Earn the Right First** — Only after the first purchase has delivered real value.
- **Relevance Over Revenue** — An irrelevant add-on costs you the whole relationship.

## Upsell vs Cross-Sell — Know Which One You're Doing

### Upselling

- Same need, higher tier or capacity.
- "You've hit the 10-user limit twice this month."
- Triggered by the customer outgrowing the plan.
- Risk: feels like a toll gate if raised too early.

### Cross-Selling

- Adjacent need, a different product entirely.
- "Site photos keep getting lost in chat — that's our mobile add-on."
- Triggered by a second problem surfacing in use.
- Risk: feels random if it isn't clearly connected.

## When to Raise an Upsell — Follow the Customer's Confidence

- **Evaluation** — Comparing options, still sceptical
- **Purchase** — Committed but nervous about rollout
- **Onboarding** — Effortful — the team is still learning
- **First Win** — A deadline hit that would have slipped
- **Expansion** — Open to more — ask HERE, not before

*Raising an add-on during the onboarding dip is the single most common upsell mistake — the customer is still paying for the last decision.*

*Source: customer-lifecycle and upsell-timing practice (illustrative arc)*

## Personalisation That Converts

You will be able to: personalise a recommendation to the buyer's stated problem rather than a generic pitch.

## What it is

- **Reference the Specific** — Name their actual project, team size or deadline.
- **Reuse Their Language** — Quote the phrase they used to describe the pain.
- **Match the Buyer Type** — Data for analytical buyers; brevity for decisive ones.
- **Time It to Their Cycle** — Fit their budget calendar, not your quarter-end.

## Adapting to the Buyer in Front of You

- **Analytical** — Wants the data, the method and the caveats.
- **Relationship** — Wants trust, references and reassurance.
- **Decisive** — Wants the headline, the price and the next step.
- **Cautious** — Wants the risk addressed and a way to reverse.

*Selling to all four the same way means you are selling well to only one of them.*

## Generic Pitch vs Personalised, Value-Earned Pitch

### Generic Pitch

- "Customers love our premium tier."
- Could have been sent to any company on the list.
- Add-on raised at the first available opportunity.
- Buyer hears a quota being filled.

### Personalised Pitch

- "You mentioned the Jurong handover — this is the piece that covers it."
- Could only have been written for this one buyer.
- Add-on raised after the first win was felt.
- Buyer hears a problem being solved.

## Where B2B Deals Are Lost

- Buyer indecision: 61%
- Lost to a competitor: 24%
- Budget withdrawn: 15%

*Illustrative composition based on reported B2B lost-deal analysis.*

*Source: B2B lost-deal synthesis (alexberman.com) — illustrative composition*

## Champion Selling

You will be able to: identify, equip and mobilise an internal champion across the buying committee.

### What it is

- **people** — Champion
- **shield** — Gatekeeper
- **chart** — Finance
- **gear** — Technical Buyer
- **star** — Executive Sponsor
- **heart** — End User

## How to Build a Champion

- **Identify** — Who gains personally if this succeeds?
- **Equip** — Give them the numbers and the one-page case.
- **Rehearse** — Prepare them for the objection Finance will raise.
- **Support** — Stay reachable while they sell it internally.

*Your champion has to win an argument you will never be in the room for. Arm them for that argument, not for your demo.*

## A Contact vs A Champion

### A Contact

- Takes your call and likes the product.
- Forwards your deck without comment.
- Goes quiet when the deal meets resistance.
- Cannot tell you who else must approve it.

### A Champion

- Gains personally when the project succeeds.
- Rewrites your case in their own internal language.
- Argues for it in the meeting you're not invited to.
- Names every stakeholder and their objection.

## The Three People You Must Convince at Sunrise Builders

- **John Tan (Project Manager · Champion)** — Goals: Stop deadlines slipping; See job status without chasing. Frustrations: Burned by a past rollout; No time to run a migration.
- **Priya Raman (Finance Director · Gatekeeper)** — Goals: Predictable annual cost; Clear payback period. Frustrations: Another recurring licence; Vague ROI claims.
- **Marcus Lee (Site Foreman · End User)** — Goals: Fewer status phone calls; Something usable on site. Frustrations: Typing reports on a phone; Anything with training.

*Source: buying-committee personas, grounded in this course's role-play scenario*

## Real-world example

### Salesforce — Land-and-Expand: Why the Second Sale Is Easier Than the First.

Salesforce built its growth on the land-and-expand model — win a small team first, prove value, then expand across departments. The principle generalises: the cheapest deal you will ever close is the next one with a customer who has already felt a win.

## Activity 2 — Role Play: Selling Techniques & Problem-Solving (Role Play)

Objective: run a problem-led demo, apply mini closes, and time an upsell correctly.

## Scenario

Alex is a sales rep for a CRM platform. Emma is Marketing Director at Northlight Retail, a growing Singapore chain with 14 outlets. Her team runs campaigns from a mix of spreadsheets, a mailing tool and WhatsApp groups. Last quarter a promotion went out twice to the same 4,000 customers, and a complaint reached the CEO.

Emma has already had one discovery call with Alex and agreed to a 45-minute demo. She is genuinely interested but has two unspoken worries: her team is not technical, and she has to justify any new spend to a finance director who has just frozen new software purchases.

The scene covers the demo itself — Educate, Demonstrate, Buy-In — with mini closes along the way, then Emma's concern about ease of use, and finally Alex's decision about whether (and when) to raise the automation add-on that would genuinely help her, without derailing the core deal.

### You'll produce

A completed Demo & Upsell Observer Scorecard citing the three problem-mapped features, the mini closes used, and the upsell timing decision with its signal (Duration: 1 hour.)

### Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **Alex — Sales Rep, CRM Platform — Goal:** *Run a problem-led demo, earn buy-in with mini closes, and judge the upsell moment.* Must resist demoing all 20 features. Only three of them map to what Emma actually said. The upsell is real and useful — but raising it before Emma has committed to the core product will cost the deal.
- **Emma — Marketing Director, Northlight Retail — Goal:** *Decide whether this solves the duplicate-send problem without breaking her team.* Interested but cautious. Will ask 'how easy is it for my team to get started?' — the real question underneath is 'will I be blamed if they don't use it?' She has a finance director who has frozen new spend.
- **Observer / Coach — Goal:** *Score the demo structure, the mini closes and the upsell timing.* Tracks whether Alex educated before demonstrating, how many mini closes were used and whether they were genuine, and whether the upsell was raised at a moment Emma was ready for — quoting the exact lines.

### How to run it — round by round

These are the detailed rounds for this role play. Work through them in order; your trainer will facilitate from the slides while you work from this guide (the matching activities/NN - <Activity>/ANN-Facilitator-Guide-\*.pdf carries the same sequence as a standalone sheet).

14. **Assign the three roles** — One learner plays Alex (sales rep, CRM system), one plays Emma (buyer, marketing director at Northlight Retail). The rest are Observer/Coach.
15. **Round 1 — lead with the problem, not the product** — Alex opens with a genuine problem-based question ('before we get into what our solution can do, can you share the challenges your team is facing right now?'). Emma describes the real mess: spreadsheets and emails, no real-time visibility, missed follow-ups.
16. **Round 2 — run Educate, Demonstrate, Buy-In in that order** — Alex Educates ('the what' — what the CRM actually centralises), Demonstrates ('the how' — walks through the dashboard using Emma's own example of a lead she's tracking), then builds Buy-In ('the why' — ties it back to the time Emma's team will get back). The demo must reference specifics Emma said in Round 1, not a generic feature tour.
17. **Round 3 — handle the objection with empathy first** — Emma raises a real concern: her team isn't very tech-savvy. Alex validates the concern before reassuring ('I completely understand') and then offers something concrete (onboarding training, a simple setup), not just 'don't worry.'
18. **Round 4 — earn the upsell, only after buy-in** — Only once Emma is ready to move forward does Alex introduce the premium analytics add-on — framed as relevant to what Emma already said she needs (prioritising high-potential leads with a smaller team), not a generic upsell script.
19. **Close with Champion Selling** — Alex frames Emma as the one bringing this win to her team ('you'll be the champion of a system that makes their jobs easier'), then confirms a specific next step (agreement sent, training session scheduled).
20. **Observer completes the scorecard** — Record the exact problem-based opening line, one specific tailored-demo moment, the exact point the upsell was raised relative to buy-in, and the Champion Selling close line.

### Suggested timing

| Minutes | Phase                                                       |
|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 min   | Brief the scenario and assign the three roles               |
| 10 min  | Round 1 — Problem-based opening                             |
| 15 min  | Round 2 — Run the tailored Educate-Demonstrate-Buy-In demo  |
| 10 min  | Round 3 — Handle the tech-comfort objection with empathy    |
| 10 min  | Round 4 — Earn the upsell, then close with Champion Selling |
| 10 min  | Observer scores the call and runs the debrief               |

### Your artefact

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard citing the problem-based opening question, one moment where the demo was visibly tailored to Emma's own words, the exact point the upsell was raised, and the Champion Selling close.

### Before you debrief — self-check

- Alex's opening question was genuinely problem-based, not a disguised pitch.
- The demo referenced at least one specific detail Emma gave in Round 1.
- The tech-comfort objection was validated before it was answered.
- The upsell was raised only after Emma signalled she was ready to move forward, and was framed as relevant to her stated need.
- The close used a Champion Selling frame and ended with a concrete next step.

### Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Watch for the demo turning into a generic feature tour — pause and ask 'how does that connect to what Emma just told you?' if it drifts.
- The upsell is the easiest step to rush — if Alex raises it before Emma has actually agreed to the core CRM, flag it in the debrief as premature.
- If time allows, have the pair re-run Round 3 with a harder objection (a recent bad experience with a different software rollout).

### Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

21. Did Alex educate before demonstrating, or jump straight to the product? What was the cost either way?
22. Which three features did Alex choose to show — and were they the three Emma actually named?
23. Count the mini closes. Which ones were genuine checks, and which were rhetorical questions that didn't invite a real answer?
24. Emma asked 'how easy is it to get started?' What was the real question underneath, and did Alex answer that one?
25. Was the upsell raised at the right moment? What signal would have told Alex to wait — or to go?
26. How did Alex equip Emma to win the argument with her finance director when he wasn't in the room?

### Reflect & Discuss

- What did showing fewer features do to the quality of the conversation?
- Which mini close would you steal for your own next demo?
- Where is the line between a helpful upsell and one that costs you the core deal?

### Debrief it

**Check:** The observer can name the three features shown and tie each to something Emma said, quote at least two genuine mini closes, identify the real question behind 'how easy is it?', and state whether the upsell was correctly timed — with the signal that justified the call.

## LU3 — Closing the Sale

Buying Signals · Closing Techniques · Justifying Price · Easy to Buy · Follow-Up

### Key concepts

- A close is the culmination of the whole sales cycle, not a single trick — read verbal, behavioural and digital buying signals before you ever ask.
- Choose an ethical close that fits the moment — Summary, Thermometer, Test Drive or Empathy Close — never manufactured urgency or pressure.
- Justify price with value and ROI before discounting is even on the table; frequent discounting quietly devalues everything else you said.
- Make it easy to buy: simple contracts, a dated mutual action plan with named owners, and de-risked options like a pilot.
- Follow up properly: 80% of sales need 5-12 touches across a 17-21 day window, and every touch must carry new value.

### What a Close Really Is

You will be able to: recognise the close as the culmination of the sales cycle, not a single trick.

### What it is

- **Build Rapport** — Establish a genuine connection with the prospect.
- **Present Value** — Demonstrate the benefit in the buyer's own terms.
- **Ask Clearly** — Finalise with an explicit, confident request.
- **Culmination** — The end result of the cycle — never an isolated trick.

### Reading the Room Before You Ask

- **Watch** — Track verbal, behavioural and digital signals.
- **Test** — Use a trial close to check readiness safely.
- **Isolate** — "Outside of that, is there anything else?"
- **Ask** — Make the request plainly, then stop talking.

*Nearly half of sales calls end without the seller ever asking. The silence after the ask belongs to the buyer — do not fill it.*

### Pushy Closing vs Empathy-Driven Closing

#### Pushy Closing

- Manufactured urgency: "this price ends tonight."
- Treats the objection as an obstacle to steamroll.
- Asks for the signature regardless of readiness.
- Wins the deal, loses the referral and the renewal.

## Empathy-Driven Closing

- Real deadlines only, stated plainly and honestly.
- Treats the objection as information to work with.
- Asks when the signals say the buyer is ready.
- Wins the deal, the referral and the renewal.

## Buying Signals — What 'Ready' Actually Looks Like

- **Verbal** — Asks about price, contract terms or implementation.
- **Verbal** — Requests references or mentions internal approval.
- **Behavioural** — Takes notes, leans in, brings in a colleague.
- **Digital** — Reopens emails, downloads material, revisits the site.

*Source: buying-signal taxonomy (monday.com; sales practice)*

## Closing Techniques That Respect the Buyer

You will be able to: select and apply an appropriate, ethical closing technique for the situation.

### What it is

- **The Summary Close** — Recap what was agreed, then ask if that sounds right.
- **The Visual Close** — Show the decision as a chart, timeline or checklist.
- **The Thermometer Close** — "On a scale of one to ten, where are you?"
- **The Empathy Close** — Name the concern honestly, then reinforce the value.

### Which Close Fits the Moment?

- **THEY'RE WARM** — Assumptive or Alternative Close — Move to logistics: "Would you prefer to start this month or next?"
- **THEY'RE UNSURE** — Thermometer or Summary Close — Surface the gap: "Where are you on a scale of one to ten — and why not a ten?"
- **THEY'RE HESITANT** — Test Drive or Empathy Close — De-risk it: name the fear, then offer a pilot instead of a commitment.

The buyer has heard everything and gone quiet. What do you actually do next?

## Ethical Closes vs Pressure Closes

### Use These

- Summary Close — confirms mutual understanding.
- Thermometer/Scale Close — invites the real objection.
- Test Drive / Puppy Dog Close — lets the product prove itself.
- Alternative Close — two genuine, good options.

### Avoid These

- **Manufactured scarcity** — a deadline you invented.
- **Guilt Close** — leveraging obligation or family pressure.
- **Sudden Death Close** — "decide right now or we're done."
- **Any close** that relies on the buyer not thinking clearly.

### Six More Closes Worth Knowing

- **Storytelling Close** — A case study they can see themselves inside.
- **Backwards Close** — Ask who else needs this — signals fit over any fit.
- **Sharp Angle Close** — Trade a real concession for a real commitment.
- **Ben Franklin Close** — Build the pros and cons list together.
- **Columbo Close** — "Just one more thing..." after the no.
- **Takeaway Close** — Remove the option that isn't earning its price.

*Source: named closing techniques (Indeed; Stowell; monday.com)*

### Justifying the Price

You will be able to: justify price with value and ROI before any discount is considered.

#### What it is

- **Emphasise Value** — Show ROI and outcome, not the feature count.
- **Support With Evidence** — Back the claim with data, studies and testimonials.
- **Frame the Long Term** — Total cost of ownership, not this month's invoice.
- **Quantify Inaction** — What does NOT solving it cost them per month?

### The Value Conversation, In Order

- **Restate the Cost** — "Two slipped handovers last quarter."
- **Attach a Number** — "You estimated S\$18k in penalties."
- **Show the Offset** — "This is S\$6k a year."
- **Let Them Conclude** — Stay quiet. The maths does the closing.

*If you cannot express the value as a number the buyer agrees with, you are not ready to discuss price at all.*

### Discounting vs Value-Justifying

#### REACHING FOR THE DISCOUNT

- **Devalues Everything** — Signals the original price was inflated.
- **Sets a Precedent** — Every renewal now starts from the discount.
- **Trains the Buyer** — They learn that waiting gets a better price.

#### JUSTIFYING THE VALUE

- **Protects the Price** — The number is defensible because it's earned.

- Trades Fairly — Concede scope or term, never value for nothing.
- Builds Respect — The buyer trusts the next number you quote.

### The Cost of Standing Still — Sunrise Builders

- **S\$18k — Cost of inaction:** estimated penalties from two slipped handovers
- **S\$6k — Annual cost:** of the proposed solution, all users included
- **3x — First-year return:** value returned against cost in year one

*Illustrative worked example — build the same three-number case for your own product before your next price conversation.*

*Source: illustrative ROI worked example, built on this course's scenario*

### Making It Easy to Buy

You will be able to: remove friction from the buying process so the decision feels simple and safe.

#### What it is

- **Simplify the Process** — Clear contracts, simple terms, obvious payment options.
- **Provide Next Steps** — A dated timeline so nobody wonders what happens now.
- **Name the Owner** — Say exactly who does what, and by when.
- **De-Risk the Decision** — Pilot, trial or staged rollout instead of all-or-nothing.

### The Mutual Action Plan

- **Agree the Goal** — The outcome and the date it must happen by.
- **List the Steps** — Every task from signature to first use.
- **Assign Owners** — A name against each step, both sides.
- **Set Check-Ins** — Dates you both already have in the diary.

*A mutual action plan turns 'we'll get back to you' into a shared document with your name and theirs on it.*

### High-Friction vs Low-Friction Buying

#### High Friction

- A 14-page contract with no summary.
- "Someone from onboarding will be in touch."
- Buyer must chase you for the next step.
- All-or-nothing commitment with no exit.

#### Low Friction

- A one-page summary attached to the contract.
- "Priya starts your setup on the 4th at 10am."

- The next step is already in both calendars.
- A 30-day pilot with a clear success measure.

### Where Buyers Drop Out After 'Yes'

- **Verbal Yes** — 100 — Buyers who said yes in the room.
- **Proposal Signed** — 72 — Reached signature without stalling.
- **Procurement Cleared** — 58 — Survived finance and legal review.
- **Live and Using It** — 44 — Actually onboarded and active.

*Every stage you fail to plan for is a stage where the deal can quietly die.*

*Source: illustrative post-agreement drop-off, deal-desk practice*

### Proper Follow-Up

You will be able to: design a persistent, value-adding follow-up cadence that is never pushy.

#### What it is

- **Be Persistent, Not Pushy** — Every touch carries new value, never just 'checking in'.
- **Thank and Reiterate** — Restate the benefit in the buyer's own words.
- **Respect Boundaries** — Honour a real no — and leave the door genuinely open.
- **Address Open Concerns** — Answer the thing they didn't quite say last time.

#### A 17-21 Day Follow-Up Cadence

- **Day 1** — Touch 1 — Thank them; reiterate the benefit in their words.
- **Day 3-4** — Touch 2 — New value — a relevant insight, not 'just checking in'.
- **Day 7-8** — Touch 3 — Address the open concern; re-confirm the timeline.
- **Day 14** — Touch 4 — A fresh angle — a case example or testimonial.
- **Day 17-21** — Touch 5 — Final proper check-in; respect the answer either way.

*80% of sales need 5-12 touches — and most sellers stop after one.*

### 'Just Checking In' vs A Value Touch

#### Just Checking In

- "Hi, just following up on my last email."
- Gives the buyer nothing new to react to.
- Puts the work of replying entirely on them.
- Easy to ignore without any guilt.

#### A Value Touch

- "Your competitor just published their delay stats — worth two minutes."
- Carries something genuinely useful every time.

- Makes replying the easy and interesting option.
- Builds a reason to stay in the conversation.

### The Follow-Up Gap

- **5-12 — Touches needed:** before 80% of sales actually close
- **1 — Touches attempted:** by the typical seller before giving up
- **17-21 — Day window:** the cadence should span, at 2-3 day intervals

*Nothing else in this course returns as much for as little effort as simply following up properly.*

*Source: follow-up benchmark synthesis (Lusha via monday.com) — industry-reported figures*

### Real-world example

#### **Wells Fargo — When Sales Targets Outrun Ethics, the Whole Franchise Pays.**

Wells Fargo's cross-selling scandal — millions of unauthorised accounts opened under intense sales quotas — led to a US\$3bn settlement in 2020 and lasting reputational damage. It is the clearest possible argument that pressure-based selling is a business risk, not just an ethical one.

#### **Activity 3 — Role Play: Closing the Sale (Role Play)**

Objective: read buying signals, justify price without discounting, and close with a mutual next step.

#### Scenario

Mark sells a marketing-automation platform. Rachel is Marketing Director at Harbourfront Living, a large Singapore e-commerce retailer. Over three conversations Mark has shown that automating their abandoned-cart and re-order campaigns would recover an estimated S\$140k a year in lost revenue.

Rachel wants it. But her budget for the year is committed, and her CFO has asked every department to defer new software to the next financial year. She opens this call by asking for a 25% discount — which is not really about the money.

The scene covers reading Rachel's buying signals, holding the price while genuinely solving her budget-timing problem, using a mini close to confirm agreement in stages, making the buying process easy, and closing on a concrete mutual action plan with dates and owners.

#### You'll produce

A completed Closing Observer Scorecard citing the buying signals, the real constraint, the price-holding trade, the closing technique used, and the mutual action plan agreed (Duration: 1 hour.)

## Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **Mark — Sales Rep, Marketing Automation — Goal:** *Close the deal without discounting, by solving the real constraint.* Has authority to vary payment terms and start date, but NOT the headline price. Must work out that Rachel's discount request is really a budget-timing problem — and that a deferred start or staged billing solves it where a discount would not.
- **Rachel — Marketing Director, Harbourfront Living — Goal:** *Get the platform approved without breaking the CFO's spending freeze.* Genuinely wants the product; opens by asking for 25% off because that is the only lever she thinks she has. Her real constraint is WHEN the money can be spent, not how much. She will reveal this only if asked well.
- **Observer / Coach — Goal:** *Score signal-reading, price-holding and the quality of the close.* Tracks the buying signals Mark noticed (and missed), whether he discounted or solved, which closing technique he used and whether it fitted the moment, and whether the call ended with a dated mutual action plan.

## How to run it — round by round

These are the detailed rounds for this role play. Work through them in order; your trainer will facilitate from the slides while you work from this guide (the matching activities/NN - <Activity>/ANN-Facilitator-Guide-\*.pdf carries the same sequence as a standalone sheet).

27. **Assign the three roles** — One learner plays Mark (sales rep, subscription marketing-automation platform), one plays Rachel (buyer, marketing director at Harbourfront Living). The rest are Observer/Coach.
28. **Round 1 — read the signal, don't force it** — Rachel is positive but hesitant about budget and time-to-ROI. Mark checks readiness directly ('if we can address the budget and timeline, would you be ready to move forward?') instead of pushing past the hesitation.
29. **Round 2 — justify the price with evidence first** — When Rachel asks about a discount, Mark justifies the price with ROI and time-savings evidence BEFORE addressing the discount question — then offers a longer-term contract with added value as the alternative to a straight price cut.
30. **Round 3 — confirm agreement with a mini close** — Mark uses a mini close to confirm the smaller decision (the longer-term-contract idea) before moving to logistics: 'to confirm, you're comfortable with a longer-term commitment if it includes more value at no extra cost — is that right?'
31. **Round 4 — remove friction and commit to a real follow-up** — Mark makes the actual buying step easy (a simple digital agreement, a specific onboarding date) and commits to a concrete, dated follow-up — not a vague 'I'll check in.'

32. **Handle the wrap-up: common flubs check** — Rachel raises a last-minute worry about past bad experiences with transitions. Mark addresses it with a specific commitment (a named support team, defined SLA) rather than generic reassurance.
33. **Observer completes the scorecard** — Record the exact buying signal, the price-justification line used before the discount question, the mini close line, and the dated follow-up commitment.

### Suggested timing

| Minutes | Phase                                                         |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 min   | Brief the scenario and assign the three roles                 |
| 10 min  | Round 1 — Read the buying signal and assess the close         |
| 15 min  | Round 2 — Justify the price before any discount talk          |
| 10 min  | Round 3 — Use a mini close to lock the agreement              |
| 10 min  | Round 4 — Make it easy to buy and commit to a dated follow-up |
| 10 min  | Observer scores the call and runs the debrief                 |

### Your artefact

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard citing the buying signal Mark responded to, the price-justification line used before any discount talk, the mini close, and the exact dated follow-up commitment made at the end.

### Before you debrief — self-check

- Mark checked readiness explicitly before attempting the close.
- Price was justified with evidence (ROI, time savings) before any discount was discussed.
- The longer-term-contract offer was framed as added value, not a disguised discount.
- A genuine mini close confirmed a smaller decision before the full close was attempted.
- The round ended with a concrete, dated follow-up commitment, not a vague promise.

### Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- The most common miss is jumping straight to a discount the moment price is raised — pause the scene and ask the pair to redo the justification step if that happens.
- Watch for the mini close being skipped entirely — without it, the final close feels like one big risky ask instead of a series of small, safe yeses.
- If time allows, add a second discount request from Rachel and have Mark hold the value line a second time.

### Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

34. What buying signals did Rachel give in the first three minutes — and did Mark act on them or talk past them?
35. Rachel asked for 25% off. What was the real constraint underneath, and which question surfaced it?
36. Did Mark hold the price? If he conceded, what did he get in return — and was it a fair trade?
37. Which closing technique did Mark use, and was it the right one for Rachel's actual state of readiness?
38. How did Mark make it easy to buy? What friction did he remove — and what did he leave in place?
39. Did the call end with a dated mutual action plan naming owners, or with 'let me come back to you'?

### Reflect & Discuss

- What would have happened to the relationship if Mark had simply granted the 25%?
- Which question best separated the stated objection from the real constraint?
- What is your own equivalent of 'vary the terms, hold the price' in your product?

### Debrief it

**Check:** The observer can quote at least two buying signals Rachel gave, state the real constraint behind the discount request and the question that surfaced it, name the closing technique used, and confirm whether the call closed on a dated mutual action plan with named owners.

## LU4 — Handling Objections & Rejections

Objection vs Deflection vs Rejection · Answer & Ask · Composure · Testimonials · Metrics

### Key concepts

- An objection asks for more information, a deflection avoids the real issue, and a rejection is a genuine no — each needs a different response.
- Acknowledge, Clarify, Address, Confirm — validate the feeling before you answer the fact, then isolate with 'outside of that, anything else?'.
- Answer & Ask resolves the stated concern directly, then re-engages the conversation with a question instead of going quiet.
- Composure is trainable: pause, label, reframe, respond, reassess — your own regulation protects the deal when the buyer gets short.
- Metrics — conversion rate, cycle length, discount depth, NPS at handoff — turn 'closing better' into something the organisation can track and improve.

## Objection vs Deflection vs Rejection

You will be able to: tell an objection, a deflection and a rejection apart and respond correctly to each.

### What it is

- **An Objection** — A request for more information. The deal is alive.
- **A Deflection** — Avoiding the real issue. Something is unsaid.
- **A Rejection** — A genuine no. Respect it and keep the door open.
- **The Test** — Ask a question — the answer tells you which one it is.

### Which One Are You Actually Hearing?

- **OBJECTION** — They want to justify it — Give value evidence and quantify inaction, then ask a question.
- **DEFLECTION** — Something else is wrong — Surface the unspoken concern gently: "If price weren't an issue, what then?"
- **REJECTION** — It is a genuine no — Accept it gracefully, ask what would change it, and leave the door open.

The buyer says: "It's too expensive right now." What is really happening?

### Reading the Difference in Practice

#### Signals an Objection

- Asks a follow-up question about terms or scope.
- Engages with your answer and pushes back on detail.
- Talks about 'when' and 'how', not 'whether'.
- Still willing to book the next conversation.

#### Signals a Rejection

- Gives no reason and asks nothing further.
- Answers in short, closed sentences.
- Shifts to the past tense: "we were looking at".
- Declines to schedule any next step.

### The Four Objections You Will Hear Most

- **"Too expensive"** — Usually a value gap or a timing constraint.
- **"Not the right time"** — Usually a priority contest you haven't won.
- **"I need to consult"** — Usually a committee you haven't mapped.
- **"We're happy as we are"** — Usually inertia, not genuine satisfaction.

*Source: common-objection taxonomy, sales practice*

## The Objection-Handling Framework

You will be able to: apply a structured, empathy-first sequence to any objection raised.

### What it is

- **Acknowledge** — Validate the feeling before touching the facts.
- **Clarify** — Ask what specifically sits behind the concern.
- **Address** — Answer the real concern with evidence.
- **Confirm** — Check it actually landed before moving on.

### Answer & Ask — Never Go Quiet

- **Answer Directly** — Resolve the stated concern without hedging.
- **Then Ask** — Follow immediately with a re-engaging question.
- **Listen Fully** — Their answer reveals the next real issue.
- **Isolate** — "Outside of that, anything else holding this up?"

*Answering and then falling silent leaves the buyer alone with their doubt. The question is what keeps the conversation alive.*

### Arguing vs Validating

#### ARGUING WITH THE OBJECTION

- "Actually, that's not right..." — Buyer digs in to defend their position.
- Buries Them in Data — More evidence, less trust.
- Rushes to Rebut — Answers before understanding the concern.

#### VALIDATING, THEN SOLVING

- "That's a fair concern." — Buyer relaxes and says more.
- Asks What's Behind It — Finds the real issue under the stated one.
- Answers, Then Checks — Confirms it landed before moving on.

### Feel · Felt · Found — Still Works After 50 Years

- **Feel** — "I understand how you feel about the switching risk."
- **Felt** — "Sunrise Builders felt exactly the same way."
- **Found** — "What they found was the pilot took nine days, not six weeks."

*Source: Feel-Felt-Found technique, in sales use since the 1970s*

## Staying Composed Under Pressure

You will be able to: regulate your own emotional response so a hostile objection does not derail the call.

### What it is

- **Separate Self From Deal** — Their no is about fit, not about your worth.
- **Buy Six Seconds** — A breath before responding prevents most regrets.
- **Name It Internally** — Labelling your own reaction reduces its intensity.
- **Reframe the Goal** — Switch from winning the point to learning the reason.

### The Five-Step Micro-Routine

- **Pause** — Six seconds. Breathe in for 3, out for 4.
- **Label** — Name your own feeling silently.
- **Reframe** — From 'win this' to 'understand this'.
- **Respond** — Neutral, fact-checking language only.
- **Reassess** — Read their reaction; adjust before continuing.

*Practise this on three live calls this week. It is the single most transferable skill in the entire course.*

### Reading the Buyer's Emotional Signals

#### What You Observe

- Short, clipped responses.
- An unusually long silence.
- Repeated questions about price.
- Voice rising, pace quickening.

#### What To Do About It

- Acknowledge the time pressure; offer to be brief.
- Let it sit, then ask an open clarifying question.
- Reframe the benefit in their own metrics.
- Slow your own pace; simplify; offer concrete choices.

### Empathy Map — Tom, Mid-Objection

- **Says** — "That's more than I wanted to spend."; "I'll need to think about it."
- **Thinks** — "Am I being talked into something?"; "What happens if it doesn't work?"
- **Does** — Folds arms; stops asking questions.; Reaches for the brochure to end the meeting.
- **Feels** — Embarrassed about the budget limit.; Anxious about making an expensive mistake.

*Source: empathy-mapping practice, grounded in this course's role-play persona*

### Testimonials & Social Proof

You will be able to: use evidence and social proof to convert scepticism without arguing.

### What it is

- **Similarity Matters Most** — Same industry, same size, same problem as theirs.
- **Specific Beats Glowing** — A number outperforms an enthusiastic adjective.
- **Timing Is Everything** — Deploy right after the concern, never before.
- **Verifiable Only** — Never invent or embellish a customer story.

### Deploying a Testimonial Properly

- **Hear the Concern** — Let them finish and validate it first.
- **Match the Story** — Pick the closest comparable customer.
- **Give the Number** — Quantify the outcome they achieved.
- **Offer the Proof** — Offer a reference call if they want one.

*A testimonial offered before the objection is marketing. Offered right after it, it is evidence.*

### A Weak Testimonial vs A Strong One

#### Weak

- "Our customers absolutely love the product."
- No name, no industry, no number.
- Delivered as a slide in the standard deck.
- Unverifiable, so easy to discount.

#### Strong

- "Sunrise Builders cut chased status updates by 70% in nine weeks."
- Named, comparable, and measured.
- Delivered at the exact moment the doubt appeared.
- Backed by an offer to speak to them directly.

### Handling a Genuine Rejection Well

- **Accept Gracefully** — "I appreciate you telling me straight."
- **Ask What Would Change It** — Learn the condition that would flip the answer.
- **Leave the Door Open** — Agree one useful touchpoint for the future.
- **Ask for the Referral** — "Who else might have this problem?"

*Source: rejection-handling and Backwards Close practice*

### Metrics of the Sales Closure Process

You will be able to: define organisational evaluation metrics that make sales closure measurable and improvable.

#### What it is

- **Conversion Rate** — Proposals that become signed deals, by stage.
- **Average Deal Size** — Revenue per closed deal, tracked over time.

- **Sales-Cycle Length** — Days from first conversation to signature.
- **Discount Depth** — Average discount given — a proxy for value selling.

### Building the Evaluation Framework

- **Define** — Name each metric and how it is calculated.
- **Baseline** — Measure the current position honestly.
- **Target** — Set a realistic improvement and a date.
- **Review** — Agree the cadence and who owns each number.

*A metric with no named owner and no review date is a number on a slide, not a management tool.*

### Choosing Metrics That Actually Drive Behaviour

**Track First:** Conversion rate by stage; Discount depth; Cheap to capture, high signal

**Worth the Effort:** Cost of customer acquisition; NPS at handoff; Harder to gather, still decisive

**Low Priority:** Raw activity counts; Calls dialled per day; Easy to game, weak signal

**Use Sparingly:** Individual win-rate leaderboards; Costly to maintain fairly; Can drive the wrong behaviour

### A Sales Closure Scorecard

- **32% — Close rate:** proposals converting to signed deals
- **41 days — Cycle length:** first conversation to signature
- **6.2% — Average discount:** given against list price
- **+48 — NPS at handoff:** customer sentiment entering onboarding

*Illustrative targets — a falling cycle length and a falling discount depth together are the clearest sign that value selling is working.*

*Source: illustrative sales-closure scorecard, performance-management practice*

### Activity 4 — Role Play: Handling Objections & Rejections (Role Play)

Objective: diagnose and respond to objections, deflections and a rejection using empathy-first technique.

#### Scenario

Sophie sells a high-end home security system. Tom is a homeowner in Bukit Timah whose neighbour was burgled six weeks ago. He requested the quotation himself, sat through the full home assessment, and agreed the system is exactly what he wants.

Then the price came up. Tom's first response is that it costs more than he wanted to spend — but he does not say that his real constraint is a renovation bill arriving next

month, and he is slightly embarrassed about it. Later in the conversation he attempts an outright rejection to end the discomfort.

The scene requires Sophie to tell an objection from a deflection from a genuine rejection, validate before solving, use Answer & Ask and a well-matched testimonial, stay composed when Tom becomes short with her, and handle the rejection attempt in a way that keeps the relationship — and the door — open.

### You'll produce

A completed Objection-Handling Observer Scorecard labelling each response as objection / deflection / rejection, with the matching technique used and the exact validating line quoted (Duration: 1 hour.)

### Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **Sophie — Sales Rep, Home Security** — *Goal: Diagnose each response correctly and respond with empathy before evidence.* Must resist rebutting the price objection with more features. Her task is to validate first, ask the question that surfaces the real constraint, and offer a genuine option — staged installation — rather than a discount.
- **Tom — Homeowner, Bukit Timah** — *Goal: Protect his budget and his pride without admitting the real reason.* Genuinely wants the system. Raises price as the objection, deflects when asked directly, and if pushed will attempt a flat rejection to escape the discomfort. Will reveal the renovation bill ONLY if Sophie validates him first and asks well.
- **Observer / Coach** — *Goal: Score the diagnosis, the validation and the composure.* Marks each of Tom's responses as objection, deflection or rejection, and checks whether Sophie's reply matched. Notes whether validation came before the answer, and whether Sophie stayed composed when Tom became short.

### How to run it — round by round

These are the detailed rounds for this role play. Work through them in order; your trainer will facilitate from the slides while you work from this guide (the matching activities/NN - <Activity>/ANN-Facilitator-Guide-\*.pdf carries the same sequence as a standalone sheet).

40. **Assign the three roles** — One learner plays Sophie (sales rep, high-end home security system), one plays Tom (homeowner, price-sensitive). The rest are Observer/Coach.
41. **Round 1 — classify before responding** — Tom raises the cost concern ('this is a bit expensive for me right now, I was hoping for something more affordable'). Before responding, Sophie (out loud, for the group) names what this is — a genuine objection, not a deflection or rejection — then asks what budget he had in mind.

42. **Round 2 — Answer & Ask, then right-size the offer** — Sophie answers the value question directly, then asks a follow-up to re-engage ('what's most important to you in a security system?'). Once Tom reveals he just wants reliable break-in alerting, not every extra feature, Sophie offers a scaled-down, lower-priced option that matches — rather than defending the original price.
43. **Round 3 — Feel-Felt-Found with a specific testimonial** — Sophie runs the full sequence out loud: Feel ('I understand your hesitation'), Felt ('many clients have felt the same way about the upfront cost'), Found (a specific, concrete story — a client whose alert genuinely caught a break-in). The testimonial must be specific, not a vague 'they loved it.'
44. **Round 4 — handle the later rejection gracefully** — In a follow-up scene, Tom tries to reject outright ('I don't think this is the right time for us'). Sophie tells this apart from the earlier objection, doesn't argue or pressure, and instead leaves the door open with a specific future check-in ('can I check back in a few months?').
45. **Observer completes the scorecard** — For each of Tom's lines, the Observer writes objection / deflection / rejection, plus the exact technique Sophie used in response — and quotes the full Feel-Felt-Found sequence.

### Suggested timing

| Minutes | Phase                                                         |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5 min   | Brief the scenario and assign the three roles                 |
| 10 min  | Round 1 — Classify the opening objection                      |
| 15 min  | Round 2 — Answer & Ask, then scale the offer to the real need |
| 10 min  | Round 3 — Reinforce with Feel-Felt-Found and a testimonial    |
| 10 min  | Round 4 — Handle the later rejection gracefully               |
| 10 min  | Observer scores the call and runs the debrief                 |

### Your artefact

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard classifying each of Tom's responses (objection / deflection / rejection) with the specific technique Sophie used against each, plus the Feel-Felt-Found sequence quoted in full.

### Before you debrief — self-check

- Tom's opening cost concern was correctly classified as an objection, not a rejection.
- Sophie used Answer & Ask — a direct answer followed by a genuine re-engaging question.
- The offer was scaled to Tom's actual stated priority, not defended at the original price.
- All three parts of Feel-Felt-Found were present, with a specific (not vague) testimonial.
- The later 'not the right time' line was correctly read as a rejection and handled without pressure, leaving a specific future check-in open.

### Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Watch for Sophie skipping straight to Feel-Felt-Found before actually answering the question Tom asked — Answer & Ask comes first.
- A generic testimonial ('they loved it') is the most common shortcut — push for a specific, concrete outcome instead.
- The hardest skill in this activity is not arguing with the final rejection — if the pair keeps pushing after 'not the right time,' stop and reset that beat.

### Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

46. Label each of Tom's three responses: objection, deflection or rejection. Did Sophie's reply match the diagnosis each time?
47. Where exactly did Sophie validate before solving — and was there a moment she jumped straight to the answer?
48. Which question finally surfaced the renovation bill? What made it safe enough for Tom to admit it?
49. When Tom became short and folded his arms, what did Sophie do with her own reaction? What would the five-step routine have changed?
50. Was the testimonial well matched to Tom, and was it deployed at the right moment?
51. Tom attempted an outright rejection. Did Sophie keep the door open in a way that was genuine rather than pushy?

### Reflect & Discuss

- What is the cost of misdiagnosing a deflection as a rejection — and vice versa?
- How did naming Tom's feeling out loud change the temperature of the conversation?
- Which objection in your own work have you been arguing with instead of validating?

### Debrief it

**Check:** The observer can label all three of Tom's responses correctly, quote the line where Sophie validated before answering, name the question that surfaced the real constraint, and describe how the rejection attempt was handled without either caving or pushing.

## Quick Reference — Activities by Learning Unit

| Learning Unit | Activity                                           | Characters                          | Duration |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------|
| LU1           | 1. Role Play: Foundations of Selling               | Jessica (sales rep) vs John (buyer) | 1 hour   |
| LU2           | 2. Role Play: Selling Techniques & Problem-Solving | Alex (sales rep) vs Emma (buyer)    | 1 hour   |
| LU3           | 3. Role Play: Closing                              | Mark (sales rep) vs                 | 1 hour   |

|     |                                                |                                   |        |
|-----|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------|
|     | the Sale                                       | Rachel (buyer)                    |        |
| LU4 | 4. Role Play: Handling Objections & Rejections | Sophie (sales rep) vs Tom (buyer) | 1 hour |

## Glossary

- **SPIN Selling** — Rackham's Situation-Problem-Implication-Need-payoff discovery-question framework (1988).
- **Cialdini's Principles of Influence** — Reciprocity, Commitment & Consistency, Social Proof, Authority, Liking, Scarcity and Unity — seven drivers of human decision-making (Cialdini, 1984 / 2016).
- **Bucket Question** — A broad opening discovery question that lets the buyer choose the topic.
- **Gap Question** — An open question that reveals the gap between the buyer's current and desired state.
- **Illusion of Choice** — Offering two good options rather than one take-it-or-leave-it proposal.
- **Mini Close** — A small, low-risk confirming question used to check buy-in before the full close.
- **Champion Selling** — Helping the buyer see themselves as the one bringing the win to their own team.
- **Feel-Felt-Found** — An objection-handling technique in sales use since the 1970s: acknowledge how the buyer Feels, note that others have Felt the same, then share what they Found.
- **Answer & Ask** — Resolve an objection directly, then ask a follow-up question to re-engage the buyer.
- **Objection / Deflection / Rejection** — A request for more information, an avoidance of the real issue, and a genuine considered no — each needs a different response.

## Support

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